EXECUTIVE SUMMARY REPORT: SUPERSTORE SALES PERFROMANCE

Project Title: Superstore Sales Analysis

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Reporting Period: January 2014 to December 2017

Date: 28th October, 2026

Overview

The analysis reveals company growth, but a third of its sales earn almost no profit. Sales rose 51% between 2014 and 2017 and the profit margin improved to 12.7%. However, the Furniture category, four loss-making states and three sub-categories are eroding profit that the rest of the business generates.

1. Business Problem

Senior management at a national retail company needs a single view of sales, profitability, customers and regions so it can see where the business makes and loses money, and act on it.

2. Data

The analysis uses the Superstore Sales Dataset consisting of:

- 9,993 order lines (after removing one duplicate)
- 5,009 orders
- 793 customers across the United States

To prepare the data for analysis, it was imported to Power Query where data types were corrected, postal codes were restored to the US 5-digit system, and new columns were added for shipping days and profit or loss status.

3. Dashboard

The two-page Power BI dashboard was built to answer the seven business questions in the brief:

- Performance Overview: 5 KPI cards, Yearly Sales Performance, Regional Sales Performance, Segment Sales Performance and Sales Trend Analysis.
- Detailed Analysis: Top 10 Most Profitable Products, Sales Performance per Product Category, Profit by State, a sub-category matrix and a Key Insights panel.
- Year, Region and Segment slicers, were added and synced across both pages, to let management filter visuals.

All figures in this report cover 2014–2017 for all regions unless stated.

Performance at a Glance

Between 2014 and 2017, the company generated **$2.30M in sales** and **$286.4K in profit**, keeping 12.5 cents of every sales dollar as profit.

KPI	VALUE	MEANING
Total Sales	$2,296,919.49	Revenue from all orders, 2014–2017
Total Profit	$286,409.08	Profit after costs and discounts
Total Orders	5,009	Unique customer orders
Average Sales	$458.56	What a customer spends per order
Profit Margin	12.47%	Total Profit ÷ Total Sales

Table 1: KPI values and meaning

Key Business Insights

Profit is concentrated in two regions and two states

The West ($725K sales, $108K profit) and East ($678K sales, $92K profit) generate 70% of all profit. Central is the weakest region, with a 7.9% margin against 14.9% in the West. At state level, California and New York earn $150K, over half of the company's profit. Texas is the 3rd-largest state by sales ($170K) but the biggest loss-maker (−$25.7K); together with Ohio, Pennsylvania and Illinois it loses $71K.

Evidence: Regional Sales Performance; Profit by State (map tooltips).

Consumers drive revenue, but Home Office is the most profitable segment

The Consumer segment brings in 50.6% of sales ($1.16M), followed by Corporate (30.7%) and Home Office (18.7%). Home Office, however, earns the highest margin (14.0%), ahead of Corporate (13.0%) and Consumer (11.5%).

Evidence: Segment Sales Performance

Technology leads, while Furniture barely makes a profit

With $836K sales and 17.4% profit margin, Technology stands as the best category. On the other hand, Furniture sells almost as much as Technology ($742K) but earns just $18.5K with a 2.5% margin.

Evidence: Sales Performance per Product Category

Copiers are the most profitable products

Copiers earn $55.6K profit at a 37.2% margin, the highest profit of any sub-category despite only 234 units sold. The single most profitable product, the Canon imageCLASS 2200 Advanced Copier, earns $25.2K, about

9% of all company profit and more than three times the next product. Three of the top 10 most profitable products are copiers.

Evidence: Top 10 Most Profitable Products & Sub-Category matrix.

The business is growing, with strong year-end peaks

There is a 51% growth in sales, and 89% growth in profit, from 2014 to 2017, lifting the margin from 10.2% to 12.7%. Growth was not smooth, as sales dipped 2.8% in 2015 before rising by 29% in 2016 and 20% in 2017. Within each year, sales followed a clear seasonal pattern where September to December brings in 52% of annual sales, while January and February are the weakest months.

Evidence: Yearly Sales Performance; Sales Trend Analysis.

Business Risks

Furniture has little return

A third of all sales ($742K) produces only 6% of profit, and Tables sub-category loses $17.7K. If Furniture sales keep growing at the current margin, revenue will rise while profit barely moves.

Profit depends heavily on two states.

California and New York produce over half of all profit. A slowdown, a new competitor or a pricing change in either state would hit company profit far harder than its share of sales suggests.

Loss-making markets are cancelling out gains elsewhere

Texas, Ohio, Pennsylvania and Illinois lose $71K, roughly half of what California and New York earn. Texas is the riskiest, as the business sells more there ($170K) yet losing money on it, so growth in such markets increases losses rather than profit.

Business Opportunities

Grow high-margin product lines

Copiers earn a 37.2% margin, and Labels (44.4%), Paper (43.4%) and Envelopes (42.3%) earn even more per dollar but make up only 5% of sales. Selling more of these lines would raise profit faster than selling more of anything else.

Expand the Home Office segment

This is the smallest segment in sales (18.7%) but the most profitable per dollar (14.0% margin).

Close the Central region's margin gap

Central sells $501K but earns only a 7.9% margin. Bringing it up to the company average of 12.5% on the same 2014–2017 sales would have added about $23K in profit without a single extra sale.

Recommendations

	RECOMMENDATION	BASIS	EXPECTED RESULT
1	Promote high-margin lines - feature Copiers, Paper, Labels and Envelopes in marketing, and bundle them with lower-margin items such as chairs	Insights 3, 4 Opportunity 1	Higher profit per order and a healthier product mix
2	Build a Home Office offer - create bundles and loyalty pricing aimed at home-based businesses.	Insight 2, Opportunity 2	More sales in the most profitable segment
2	Fix or cut loss-making Furniture lines - raise prices on Tables and Bookcases, renegotiate supplier costs, or remove the worst-performing products	Insight 3 Risk 1	Recover the $21K that Tables and Bookcases lost over the four years and lift the Furniture margin
3	Run a profitability review in Texas, Ohio, Pennsylvania and Illinois - check pricing, discounts and shipping costs before pushing more sales in these states	Insight 1 Risk 3	Stop losses that totaled $71K over four years; make growth in these states add profit
4	Apply West-region practices to Central - compare West and Central pricing and product mix, and set a margin target for Central managers	Insight 1 Opportunity 3	About $23K more profit over a four-year period if Central reaches the company margin
6	Plan around the seasons - increase stock and staff before September–December, and run promotions in January–February to lift the slowest months.	Insight 5	Fewer stock-outs at peak and steadier monthly sales

Table 2: business recommendations

Conclusion

Overall, the business is healthy, with Technology, the West and East regions, and California and New York generating strong profits. The main threat is unprofitable sales with Furniture category.

Management's priority should be to protect margin before chasing more volume. Fixing loss-making products and states recovers profit, while promoting high-margin lines and practicing seasonal planning set up the next stage of profitable growth.